Yesterday I Saw the Sun

By Ally Sheedy

INTRODUCTION

The publisher claims that Ally Sheedy's book of poetry, Yesterday I Saw the Sun, is "a work of fiction". If only that were the case. Then the contents in it wouldn't break your heart. Ally Sheedy, famous in the 80s as part of the "Brat Pack" – Remember her angst ridden role in Breakfast Club – was and is more than just a celebrity. She is a survivor who gives new definition to the word. From drug addiction and domestic abuse to questioning her own sanity and a desire to end her own life . . . Ally Sheedy has survived. Today she lives with her daughter, Rebecca, in NYC and is still working in the film industry.

Selections from Yesterday I Saw the Sun by Ally Sheedy

Xmas Break

So why'd you hit me, huh?
Did you have to go and do that?
And I've been working so hard on myself, too.

I had a moment of clarity
One night
It was during Christmas.

I was outside barefoot in the East Coast snow.

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Dead of winter, dead of night.
He was looking for a rooftop murderer.
Running around the house with
a baseball bat.
"Shut up and get inside!"
he screamed.

I looked up.
The sky was filled with bright blue stars
twinkling like
Christmas lights.
Smoke was curling out the chimney of his cozy hearth..
It was cold.

Crouching down by a bush in the rocks
I listened for the frantic sounds
of escaping rooftop killers.
He tears past me with the bat.
Slams into the house.
"Get inside!" he screams again.
So I follow.

I sit on the sofa by the Christmas tree
looking up again.
This time at the ceiling.
Sounds of bangs and frantic thumps
rain down on my head.

I hug my knees into my chest and count in silence
backward
slowly with each breath from 99.

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So sad.

When I reach 36, he is back.
With his bat.
"Who left the window open?" he demands.
Scary. Low.
I look all around me for the answer.
But we are alone.

"I did," I sigh. "I guess."

He comes up in my face.
His teeth are stained dark.
The eyes are crazy.
The bat's an inch from the bridge
of my freckled nose.
"There's no one else here," he breathes.
"I guess you did."

Have you ever known an angry crazy drinking man?
Have you ever been thrown in with that rage?
Alcoholic sweat --
Do you know that smell?

I do.
I did.
I left the window open.
He breathes.
I keep his bat
in view.

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I try
to find
my mind.

In the East now for a week
prisoner
insane

(Beat – speaker shifts from speaking to the audience to speaking to her abuser – focus should change as well as demeanor)

You grab me by the chin and
and stare into my eyes.
"You left an open window. In there. Don't lie.
Tell me who you are seeing."

It comes to me
a flash of
what will come.
There is no mistaking or escaping this.
You want to kill me.
I mean I saw it was beyond
returning sane.
"NO ONE I swear. I'm so sorry. Forgive me, baby,
please."

(Beat – speaker shifts from speaking to her abuser to speaking with the audience again)

Without a backward glance I let go the rope

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slipped away
drowned myself
in chemical reprieves.
And I knew where the door was. All along.

Coke's on the table
a girl on the floor
bottles all around

(Beat – speaker shifts from speaking to the audience to speaking to her abuser – focus should change as well as demeanor)

You fall unconscious and I try
to rub away the dread
of what I know.
I long to sleep and dull
that clear moment when I'm hit.
To render weightless what I bear in what I've seen.
I can forget. I can forget.

And yet I stay awake
trying to retrieve
the moment
where you say
I asked for it.

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TRANSISTION

And finally, at the age of 27, Ally Sheedy realized that she needed help – She checked herself into Minnesota's Hazelden Foundation. She begged for help with a drug addiction, but in reality the drug use was a symptom of a much larger problem . . .

MY DISEASE

I don't understand this sickness.

it is the observer
watching me through a telephoto lens
reporting on me in its private tabloids
waiting patiently in the bush

like the fan with a gun
in a fascinated all-encompassing horrifying trance
it waits
distorting my every detail
magnifying y every transgression
hypnotic

some days are nightmares
coming off the drugs
I look at my skull in the mirror and wonder
how so much rage can be contained within
such a narrow circumference
of bone

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there is a rec room at the Center
with a saggy well-worn couch
while the others watch CNN and smoke
I crouch in the corner and hold my head together
with my hands
to keep it from breaking in a cracked web.

I can see the sickening thoughts and violent images
come crawling out
like so many little black spiders
swarming over my face m y neck my eyelids
When there is a break in the action
I stand up and go to the vending machine
to get a Diet Mountain Dew.

I used to sit at a kitchen table in the sun
and hem myself in safely with stacks of morning papers.
I drank coffee watching the clock tick
watching the orange-papered kitchen shelves
and the little black cat on the garden wall.
I was afraid to move.

Now I am split beyond my shell
and roam as far as the grounds can go
I shoot basket after basket
I swim lap after lap
and there are nurses who, like creases in a sheet,
smooth me into flattened sleep

but mostly the sickness with the gun is absent
unsuccessful yet in tracking me down

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I have been safe here for three weeks
within walls that are, finally, not of my making.

For the first time in my life
I gladly welcome my restraints.
There is no prison like the one
where I used to live.

TRANSISTION

Three-months drug free, Ally was released from the treatment center . . . cured of her drug addiction, but still fragile . . . so fragile inside. In this last poem, she creates an extended metaphor, comparing her daily struggle to that of a crippled baby bird . . . "Please let me live"

HEROICS

I found a baby bird yesterday.
I was climbing up a hill.
the bird was by the side of my path
fluttering in the undergrowth.
It had a crippled left leg and looked up at me
with the sweetest darkest little bird face
Don't kill me, I thought I heard it say.
Please let me live.
I cupped it in my hands and held it to my heart.
I love you, I said.
I will save you from the coyotes by carrying you to a
safer place.

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Really, you are very fortunate that I happened by.
But this bird did not seem to agree
and struggled desperately in my grasp.
Its wings beat and beat against my chest --
fighting me.
I did try to calm it
but it was drowning.
Little bird, I said telepathically. Why struggle so?
I have always longed to swim and float on the waves of
someone else's
deep desire to save me.
Can't you relax and enjoy it?
But it only fought me harder
Angrily dissolving into a tiny puddle of tears
and wet feathers
within my grasping palm.
This was an ungrateful creature.
I opened my hand to the sun
to see what was left of it.

I was halfway up the hill now
the trail becoming steep and narrow
with jagged rocks falling away on either side.
I looked to the top of the hill
and wondered why I was still trying.
Such an effort to conquer another canyon trail.
For what?
To feel I was in some small way
correcting my misshapen parts?
To achieve a victory over an obstacle?

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These were the philosophical ramblings
banging pointlessly inside my head.
This was my state of mind.
You are an idiot, I said.
Alone on this hill.
Trapped, exhausted, covered with dust and
crying suddenly at the ludicrousness of it all.

That was when the bird stirred in the sun and
lifted its small black head.
Did it think of freedom?
It seemed conflicted for a second
then seized its chance
and zoomed straight up into the air
toward the sun
it *leapt*
broken leg and all
before I could grab it again.

I saw it suspended for a moment
in a frozen shining silhouette
of absolute abandonment and wild joy
and then I could swear to you I heard that little bird
laugh
crying out in victory
before it feel onto the rocks
disappearing below.
It was to me an act of heroism that made me envious.

A bird had the courage to throw itself off a mountain
to escape

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the sweat and constraint
of a human hand.
Where is my leap?

And, you know, I did keep climbing that hill
I didn't turn back halfway
because I needed that moment
When I reached the top and faced
for a split second
the desire to throw myself over the side
to fall
completely free
unsaved
unstopped
unchained
recklessly abandoning myself to gravity and to
everything
escape
I want it so much
Don't I?

I remain. It's my struggle to stay alive and be braver
than
a little bird
who has suffered from a crippled leg
but never – once – a crippled soul.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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